

"When a girl who swore herself unlovable meets a boy whose heart knows only love, the universe holds its breath—wondering if walls will crumble or hearts will break."

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Chapter 1

Scarlett

The clock on my phone blinked 8:00 AM, and my heart dropped. The second I glanced at the time, I knew the entire morning had slipped away without me even realizing it. It was a strange feeling. How could I have zoned out so completely?

I quickly brushed the thought aside and stood up from my bed, shaking off the drowsiness that always seems to linger for far too long after waking up. The girls would already be up and getting ready, knowing how punctual Sofia and Carla were. Maya, on the other hand, probably still had a few more hours before her alarm went off. The girl could sleep through anything.

I shuffled toward the bathroom, caught a glimpse of my reflection, and sighed. I'd spent years perfecting a mask—an armor of sorts—that I wore in public. But the truth was, behind that mask, there was always a quiet storm brewing within me. And today, of all days, it seemed louder than usual. An anxiety storm. The one that made me question every step I took, every decision I made. It was all so... overwhelming.

But I couldn't afford to let that get to me today. Today was important.

After splashing my face with cold water, I got dressed in my usual black jeans, a simple white blouse, and my sneakers, and hurried to the living room. Sofia was sitting on the couch, scrolling through her phone, her legs crossed in a way that only she could pull off. She looked like she belonged in some kind of magazine ad, even though I knew she didn't care for all the attention. Her presence was always bold, but there was something about her calm demeanor this morning that made me feel grounded. Maybe it was just the familiarity of having her around.

"Morning, Scarlett. You look... stressed." Sofia's voice had that cool, composed edge that she always carried with her.

“Can’t help it,” I muttered, walking toward the kitchen to make myself a cup of coffee. “Just... a lot going on.”

Sofia gave me that knowing look. She knew exactly what I was going through. I had to prepare for my internship interview at Microsoft today, and the pressure felt like it was closing in from all sides.

Carla entered the room just then, already looking ready for the day. She was always punctual—organized, efficient, and on top of things. She was the kind of person who could get her entire life together without breaking a sweat. If there was one person I envied in this apartment, it was her. She exuded control, something I was constantly fighting to maintain.

“Hey,” Carla greeted us, her voice pleasant but with an edge of concern. “You okay, Scarlett?”

“Sure, I’m fine,” I lied, my voice betraying me. “Just nervous. You know the usual.”

Carla rolled her eyes in a playful way, crossing her arms over her chest. “It’s not like you to freak out over an interview. I know you. You’ve got this.”

I wanted to believe her, I really did. But deep down, I couldn’t shake the feeling that I was going to mess it all up. I’d failed before. A lot. Why should this time be any different? It wasn’t as though I had any experience or connections to help me stand out. I was just another intern with no real idea what I was doing.

Maya finally wandered into the room, her hair messy and her eyes still half-lidded. She yawned loudly, stretching her arms out like a cat.

“I’m awake, I’m awake,” she said, her voice thick with sleep. “No need to remind me. What’s the panic about, Scarlett?”

“Interview,” I muttered, my stomach sinking as I said the word out loud again. It felt like the weight of the world was resting on this one interview. If I didn’t get it, then... what was I even doing here? What was I working toward?

Maya gave me a lazy grin, the kind that only she could manage. “You’re going to crush it. You’ve got this in the bag. Plus, Microsoft’s lucky to have someone as cool as you. And hey, if it doesn’t work out, you’ll still be amazing. Always.”

Sofia and Carla nodded in agreement, and for a moment, I felt a flicker of hope. Maybe they were right. Maybe I *could* do this.

The moment of optimism didn't last long, though. The familiar unease crept back into my mind as I walked toward the door, ready to leave for the interview. As much as I tried to push it away, the nagging voice in my head kept asking, "What if you mess up? What if you're not good enough?"

I shook my head, forcing myself to focus. I didn't have time for doubts. I didn't have time to fail. I had a future to secure, and this internship was the first step.

As I walked out of the apartment, I found myself lost in thought, rehearsing my answers in my head. I had gone over everything a hundred times. What made me interested in Microsoft? What skills could I bring to the company? What was my biggest achievement? My heart raced as I thought about the interviewers, how they'd be sitting there, evaluating every word I said, every move I made.

By the time I reached the Microsoft office building, my palms were sweating, and my stomach had turned into knots. I stepped into the elevator, trying to steady my breathing. But when I reached the floor, I couldn't help but feel like I was walking into a completely different world.

The moment I stepped into the lobby, I was greeted by a woman at the reception desk. Her smile was warm, but I could sense the professionalism in her demeanor. She led me to the waiting area where other candidates were already seated, all of them dressed in their best interview attire. They were all so... confident. So poised.

I sat down and tried to calm myself, keeping my thoughts in check. I glanced around at the other candidates, feeling like I didn't belong. But I wasn't here to compare myself to others. I was here to prove that I deserved this opportunity.

When my name was called, I stood up immediately, trying not to show the tremor in my legs. I was led into the interview room, where I was greeted by two serious-looking interviewers. They introduced themselves briefly, but I barely heard a word. My mind was buzzing with a thousand thoughts, and for a moment, I almost forgot why I was there.

The interview went by in a blur. They asked questions, and I answered them as best I could, my voice steady despite the chaos in my head. I kept reminding

myself that I had prepared for this, that I had the skills, that I was more than just someone who didn't belong.

And then, just when I thought they were about to wrap things up, one of the interviewers smiled and leaned forward.

"Scarlett," he said, his voice warm and inviting. "We'd like to offer you the internship position at Microsoft."

For a moment, I thought I had misheard him. I blinked, trying to process the words. Was this real? Was this really happening?

"Yes," I whispered, my voice shaky but filled with relief. "Yes! Thank you!"

I walked out of that room feeling lighter than I had in weeks. The weight that had been pressing down on me was gone, and for the first time in a long while, I felt like I had finally done something right. Something that mattered.

Chapter 2

Jude

I pace around my apartment, phone pressed to my ear as I check my emails for the hundredth time. My inbox is full of spreadsheets, business proposals, and the usual clutter of work emails. It's funny how when you're building your empire, it's not the small stuff that gets to you, but the looming responsibility of it all. Everything has to be just right.

"Alright, man," Ethan's voice cuts through the murkiness of my thoughts. "You seriously gonna let me run this whole thing while you're busy finding your next... 'project'?" His sarcasm is thick enough to cut with a knife. Ethan Montgomery never misses a chance to remind me that he's the more grounded one between the two of us.

I smirk, leaning against the counter. "I told you, I'm delegating the busy work. You're better at the spreadsheets and the legal stuff. I'll handle the... 'vision'." I say that with my best attempt at sounding mysterious, which is more of a joke than anything else.

"Vision, huh? Well, if your 'vision' involves another weekend of charming some woman and pretending to be 'deep,' we might be in trouble." Ethan's dry laugh is all too familiar.

"Hey, not every woman gets my attention," I say, feigning offense. "Some of them actually intrigue me."

"Yeah, I've heard this one before." His voice is drenched in skepticism. "What is it this time? Are you looking for a woman to... what, challenge you? Like emotionally or...?"

I roll my eyes, even though he can't see me. "I'm not saying I'm not interested in a little... relaxation. But seriously, there's more to life than work and distractions."

"Oh really? So what's this 'more' you're talking about? You're not thinking of becoming one of those boring, successful guys who hides behind a computer

and talks business all day, are you?" Ethan teases, his voice laced with mock concern.

"Maybe. Or maybe I'll just keep my weekends open for more... spontaneous encounters," I respond with a grin. I'm pretty sure that'll make him roll his eyes. Ethan's never been one for the casual flings I indulge in.

"Sure, whatever. Just don't get so lost in your 'vision' that you forget you've got an empire to build." He sounds serious now, but the humor is still there. "I'm not going to be the one picking up the slack."

"I know, I know." I laugh, clinking my coffee mug against the counter. "You're a good guy, Ethan. That's why you're my business partner."

"Business partner," he mutters. "I'll believe it when I see it. But seriously, don't go getting any 'grand ideas' until I get this proposal done, okay?"

"Deal," I say, leaning back into the couch. My phone buzzes in my pocket, interrupting our banter. I pull it out and glance at the message, then swipe it away. Nothing too urgent.

"Alright, I'm gonna grab lunch," Ethan says, "but we'll need to sync up soon. Maybe tonight?"

"Sure, text me when you're free," I reply, cutting the call. I place the phone back down on the table and stretch out, closing my eyes for a second. Sometimes, the business talk is draining, but it's all worth it. We're building something big, and there's no turning back now.

It's a few hours later when I finally grab my jacket and head out to the Microsoft office for the meeting. I'm supposed to be there early, but I know how these things go—meetings rarely start on time. As I walk through the lobby, I take in the familiar sight of the building. I love this place—clean, modern, and everything about it screams power.

I make my way to the waiting area, passing the usual sea of interns and employees. There's the usual nervous energy in the air, with people typing away on laptops, checking their phones, or just... waiting. And then, I spot her.

At first, I don't even realize who it is. It's not until I pass by the row of chairs and glance toward a corner where I spot someone sitting by herself that something clicks. She's got those cherry-red curls, the kind that catches light like fire. Her eyes... yeah, they're there, too, but they don't seem to match her appearance. There's something... off. I can't quite place it.

She's got that air about her, the one that says she's not here to impress anyone, but there's an undercurrent of anxiety beneath the calm exterior. She's probably here for an interview, or maybe she's just waiting to be called for something else. I keep walking, but something pulls me back, even though I try to shove the thought aside. What was it? Just a fleeting glance, right?

I shake my head. No time for distractions. I'm here for business, and that's all that matters. It's just a coincidence, right? A face in the crowd, someone who's probably just another intern.

I shove the thought away, mentally berating myself.

I grab my coffee from the counter and take a long sip, the heat seeping into my system as I prepare for whatever's next. Then I hear the door swing open, and the receptionist greets me. Time to work.

But, as I walk into the conference room, my mind briefly flickers back to her again. Just a moment. That's it.

But why did I notice her at all?

Chapter 3

Scarlett

The day of the meeting had arrived, and I wasn't prepared for the flood of emotions that would hit me once I stepped into the conference room. It was my first big meeting at Microsoft, and I could already feel the weight of all the eyes on me, even though they probably weren't.

I made my way to my seat, trying not to look too out of place. The conference hall was large and sleek, all glass walls and steel frames. People filed in, shaking hands, talking in quiet murmurs about the agenda, their voices blending together into a soft hum. But amidst all the noise, I couldn't shake the feeling that I was standing in the center of the storm, exposed.

I scanned the room, looking for a familiar face—any familiar face—to ground me. That's when I saw them: Jude Emerson and Ethan Montgomery.

I had seen them before in passing, but this was different. They were both at the front of the room, discussing something with the group of people who had gathered for the meeting. Their chemistry was undeniable—two people who had worked together long enough to understand each other's thoughts before they even spoke.

Ethan was a striking figure. Tall, with a sharp jawline and dark brown hair that was neatly combed back, his dark eyes scanning the room with an expression of detached amusement. His suit was impeccable—dark gray with a crisp white shirt and a slim tie that added a touch of sophistication. He seemed to have a way of drawing people in with his quiet confidence, a subtle yet powerful energy that made it hard not to listen when he spoke. He was with a few colleagues who were equally polished and well-dressed, their conversation flowing smoothly as they prepared for the meeting.

But it was Jude who caught my attention more than anyone else.

I didn't mean to stare, but it was hard not to. He had this aura of authority, one that wasn't born out of arrogance but out of sheer presence. His suit was darker

than Ethan's, a deep navy that contrasted against his pale skin. His shirt, a soft blue, brought out the green in his hazel eyes, eyes that seemed to miss nothing. His tousled brown hair—dark but with a natural wave—looked like he'd spent no time perfecting it, yet somehow it worked.

His sharp jawline was set in a way that made him appear serious, but there was a subtle warmth in his gaze when he spoke, like he truly cared about what others had to say. Despite the formal setting, Jude had an air of casual confidence, as though nothing could faze him.

I shifted uncomfortably in my seat, trying to calm my nerves. It wasn't like I wanted his attention, but something about his effortless charm made me feel like I was playing catch-up.

The room settled as the meeting began. It wasn't long before the conversation turned into a business discussion—something far over my head. I barely knew the lingo they were throwing around, and I was sure the others in the room could tell.

Jude was at ease, his words precise as he made his point. "Our metrics from last quarter indicate a clear trend toward an increased market share. But we need to evaluate the strategic pivots we can make moving forward, particularly in Q2. I believe a focus on the emerging markets will serve us well, but we need to account for the competitive landscape. Ethan, can you provide a deeper dive into the projections?"

Ethan, who was standing beside Jude, nodded, his posture relaxed but attentive. "Absolutely," he said, adjusting his tie. "We've run the numbers for both short-term and long-term projections, and we're seeing some interesting patterns. The focus will be on building out partnerships in Southeast Asia and Latin America—those markets have high potential, but we need to mitigate risks regarding supply chain constraints."

As they spoke, I found myself tuning in, not because I fully understood what they were saying, but because of the way they spoke. There was a rhythm to their words, a fluidity between them that came from years of collaboration. It was like watching two well-oiled machines in motion, the ease with which they handled business making the whole process seem effortless.

I glanced around the room at the others, most of them taking notes and nodding along, but I couldn't tear my eyes away from Jude. The way he moved, the way he spoke—it was almost hypnotic. He had a natural ability to command attention without even trying, while Ethan exuded a quieter, more calculated energy that balanced Jude's exuberance perfectly.

I couldn't help but feel out of place.

Scarlett, you're just an intern. Stop overthinking. I told myself, forcing my gaze away from them. I grabbed my notebook and tried to focus, jotting down some notes even though half of what was being discussed went over my head.

I could hear their voices floating through the air, their business talk mingling with the buzz of the other discussions in the room, but I couldn't help but observe how easily they interacted. Jude, with his charming smile and relaxed gestures, effortlessly moving the conversation forward. He was completely comfortable in his own skin, and it showed in everything he did.

Even when the conversation drifted slightly off-topic, he was quick to steer it back, never missing a beat. His voice was clear, calm, and always just the right amount of persuasive. It wasn't loud, but everyone in the room listened when he spoke. It was like he had a magnetism to him, an intangible quality that pulled people in and made them want to hear what he had to say.

I couldn't help but feel... small. There I was, trying to keep up with the conversation, worrying about saying something wrong, while Jude and Ethan seemed to operate on a different level entirely.

But then I noticed something else. Jude's effortless charm wasn't just for show. He genuinely engaged with the people around him, making small jokes or asking follow-up questions that showed he was paying attention. It wasn't just about the business talk—it was about making connections.

At one point, he glanced over at the group of us interns. His eyes swept over us briefly before moving on, but there was a slight twitch of a smile on his lips, almost as if he knew we were all a little lost in the conversation.

I quickly looked away, my heart racing for no reason. But I couldn't stop thinking about how natural he made it all look—how smooth his movements were, how effortlessly he transitioned from one topic to the next.

The meeting ended sooner than I expected, and everyone started gathering their things, preparing to leave. I stood up, feeling my nerves flood back. I was already out of place in that room. I didn't need to stick around and make it worse by stumbling through another awkward moment.

But as I glanced across the room, I saw Jude again. He was talking to someone—a woman who seemed equally at ease as he was. They were laughing about something, and I caught a glimpse of the way his eyes twinkled when he smiled. It wasn't anything personal; I knew that much. But I couldn't help but notice how he could make anyone feel comfortable, even in a professional setting like this one.

I didn't have that ability.

As the meeting broke up and people started filtering out, I walked toward the door with the others.

My phone buzzed in my pocket, and I pulled it out, glancing at the screen.

"Maya: You surviving that meeting? No one noticed you, huh?"

I couldn't help but laugh a little, even though it wasn't entirely true. Jude had noticed me. Whether he had any reason to or not, I wasn't sure. But I wasn't going to read too much into it.

"Nope, made it through. Barely," I typed back.

I tucked my phone back into my bag and walked out of the conference room, trying to shake off the lingering feeling that I was watching life happen instead of participating in it.

But that's what I did, wasn't it? Watch. I didn't belong here. I was just an observer, waiting for the day I'd find my voice.

And who knew how long that would take?

The rest of the day was a blur. The usual humdrum of office work, the clicking of keyboards, the low murmurs of colleagues exchanging ideas—it all felt distant as I replayed the conference scene in my head. But more than anything, my mind kept drifting to *him*—Jude Emerson.

When the workday ended, I rushed out of the office, trying to shake off the overwhelming sense of nervousness that had plagued me since the moment I laid eyes on him. There was no reason to get worked up, right? He was just another person. A well-dressed, confident, impossibly attractive person. But still, I couldn't help myself. His presence had a way of making everything else fade into the background.

"Scarlett!" Sofia called as I walked out the office building. "You're coming to the club, right?"

I glanced at my phone—there was a message from Carla. *"We're celebrating tonight, you in or what?"*

I could already feel the excitement building in my chest. My friends were my rock. They always knew how to lift my spirits, and tonight, we'd be letting loose. I typed back quickly: *"Of course. I'll be there!"*

By the time I made it home and changed into something a little more fun and a lot less professional, I felt a strange sense of anticipation. The evening ahead felt like a chance to forget everything else, to just be myself and enjoy the moment. And after all, who didn't need a little fun every now and then?

The club was packed when I arrived, the bass of the music vibrating in my chest. It was a trendy spot in Manhattan, filled with neon lights and people dancing, laughing, living in the moment. The place had an electric energy, the kind of atmosphere that made it impossible not to smile.

Sofia, Carla, and Maya were already at the bar, chatting and ordering drinks. The moment I joined them, Sofia wrapped an arm around my shoulders, her ever-present spark of energy lighting up my mood. "You made it! We were waiting for you to let loose!"

Carla gave me a knowing look. "I can already tell you're about to dance the night away."

I rolled my eyes, but there was a smile tugging at my lips. "We'll see about that," I teased, accepting the cocktail Maya handed me. The fruity drink was a welcome distraction, easing the tightness in my chest that had only seemed to grow stronger over the past few hours.

We found a corner near the dance floor where we could hang out and people-watch. The place was filled with attractive people, all looking for their moment in the spotlight. Carla immediately started scanning the room. "Who's your type tonight, Scarlett?" she asked with a mischievous grin.

I laughed, shaking my head. "I'm not really here to pick anyone up, you know. I just came to have fun."

Maya chimed in, her voice light. "But you *could* pick someone up, right? You know, just for a night."

I felt my cheeks warm. "I don't know... I'm not feeling it tonight."

Sofia raised an eyebrow. "Uh-huh. Sure." She nudged me playfully. "You can't hide that look in your eyes. I can tell you're already scouting the crowd."

I froze, my gaze briefly drifting across the room. As my eyes scanned the crowd, they locked on a familiar figure walking toward the bar.

I could feel my heart skip a beat. It was him.

Jude Emerson.

He looked casual, but effortlessly stylish, wearing a navy blue blazer over a simple white shirt with the sleeves rolled up slightly. His jeans were dark, fitted just right, and his shoes polished to perfection. He had an air of confidence about him that was almost magnetic, but it was the subtle way he carried himself, the cool, collected aura around him, that stood out most.

I blinked, trying to shake myself out of the trance his presence had put me in. The last thing I needed was to lose my composure in front of my friends.

Sofia, of course, noticed my sudden stillness. "You okay, Scarlett?" she asked, her tone filled with mischief. "I thought you were gonna pass out for a second."

I turned to face her, forcing a casual smile. "I'm fine. Just... got distracted for a second."

Maya peered over at me, then turned her attention to the bar. "I see what distracted you." Her voice was full of playful teasing. "It's Jude Emerson, isn't it?"

My stomach did a somersault. "Who?" I asked, trying to sound nonchalant, even though I knew exactly who she meant.

Carla laughed, a knowing glint in her eye. "You can't hide that look, Scarlett. You've been checking him out ever since you walked in here."

Sofia leaned in, grinning. "It's okay, no judgment. I mean, come on. The man is *fine*." She gestured toward him, subtly pointing him out.

I felt a knot of anxiety tighten in my chest. "I wasn't checking him out."

"Mm-hmm," Maya said, her tone dripping with sarcasm. "Sure, you weren't. Look at your face."

I shot her a glare, but there was no denying it. I had been watching him, and I didn't even know why. He was just another guy, right? So why was my heart racing?

"Stop teasing me," I muttered, but the truth was, I was *very* aware of him now. My mind kept wandering back to the conference room, to the way he had effortlessly commanded the room. His words were still echoing in my head, even though he hadn't spoken to me directly. I wanted to hear his voice. I wanted to know more about him, even though I was trying hard not to let myself get caught up in it.

"Okay, okay, I'll stop," Sofia said, raising her hands in mock surrender. "But you can't blame us for pointing it out. He's the kind of guy who makes heads turn."

I sighed, rolling my eyes. "I don't care about guys right now. I'm here to enjoy myself."

Carla gave me a skeptical look. "Enjoy yourself *and* let loose, Scarlett. You can't be this uptight all the time. Go talk to him. It's just a conversation."

I turned to face her, trying to focus on the drink in my hand. "I'm not looking for anything serious, okay? I don't even know him."

Sofia nudged me again. "Who said anything about serious? Just... you know, flirt a little. Have some fun."

I opened my mouth to protest but then stopped myself. I wasn't here to argue. Maybe they were right. I wasn't trying to find love or anything deep. I just wanted to have a fun night. No strings attached. Just like every other girl here.

I glanced back toward the bar, but Jude was nowhere to be seen. Had he left already? I was hoping to maybe... run into him. But then I heard a familiar voice.

"Sooo, Scarlett," Maya said in a teasing tone, "How about we go hit the dance floor? That'll take your mind off *him* for a bit."

I chuckled, shaking my head. "You guys are crazy."

Sofia grinned. "Let's see what the night has in store for us. Just have fun, okay? No thinking about work or anything else."

I took a deep breath, letting her words sink in. "Alright, alright. Let's dance."

As we made our way toward the dance floor, the lights flashing and the bass pulsing in my veins, I decided to put the whole "Jude" thing out of my head. For tonight, it was all about having fun with my friends, letting go of all the pressure. So I did.

And just as I found my rhythm, a new guy came up to me, looking like he was ready for a good time. I didn't give him much thought—he was just a distraction, and that was exactly what I needed right now.

"Hey, you look like you're having fun," he said, a playful grin on his face. "Mind if I join you?"

I raised an eyebrow but didn't hesitate. "Sure, why not?" I said, matching his energy. This was exactly what I needed—a casual night out with no expectations. Just dancing and enjoying the night.

As we danced, my mind kept drifting back to *him*, but I shoved the thought aside. Tonight was mine. I was determined to enjoy every moment of it.

Chapter 4

Jude

The conference room was bustling with conversation as the employees filed in, finding their seats, preparing for the meeting. As always, I was punctual, arriving early enough to snag my usual spot near the centre. Ethan was already there, leaning back in his chair and scanning the room. He noticed me immediately and gave me a knowing grin.

"Jude," he greeted with a playful smile, "ready for another one of these mind-numbing meetings?"

"Not exactly," I muttered, running my fingers through my hair. "But we all know we have to be here. No choice."

Ethan laughed, a low, amused sound, clearly unfazed by the monotony. "True. But at least we get to catch up on all the gossip, right?" His eyes scanned the room again, landing on various people as he made his mental notes on who was worth talking to.

The room filled quickly, and soon everyone settled into their seats. I casually glanced around, trying to make sense of the faces I saw--people I'd seen before, employees I'd interacted with, the usual crowd. But then, as I moved my gaze toward the door, I saw her.

Scarlett.

She walked in just then, and it was like the air in the room shifted. She wasn't loud, wasn't trying to draw attention, but somehow, she had a presence. Her cherry-red hair, always so meticulously kept in place, cascaded over her shoulders in waves today, but it was her eyes that caught my attention first. There was something in them--something guarded. They weren't expressive, not like some people's, but there was an intensity behind them that spoke

volumes. As if there were a thousand thoughts racing through her mind that she wouldn't let escape.

She scanned the room, her gaze flitting nervously over the people she'd likely worked with, but she didn't linger. She moved toward an empty seat and sat down, her posture tense. Even though we were in a meeting surrounded by colleagues, I couldn't shake the sense that she was alone in the crowd.

I couldn't help but observe. She was so... different from anyone else in the room. Her silence, her hesitation—it was all so foreign to the typical corporate environment we worked in. Yet, there was a beauty in her quietude. A rawness that contrasted sharply with the polished, almost rehearsed personas of the other employees around us. I didn't understand it, but I couldn't pull my focus away from her.

The meeting began, and I pushed thoughts of her to the back of my mind, turning my attention to the presentations. But I couldn't help it. Every time I glanced at her, I saw her tense up, her fingers tapping nervously on the table. She was trying to appear calm, trying to blend in, but there was something about her—the way she looked at her notes, the subtle way she bit her lip as she thought, that told me she was anything but calm.

I noticed how she barely spoke during the meeting. When someone directly addressed her, she'd respond quietly, almost shyly, as though unsure of herself. But her answers were sharp and precise—she knew her stuff. That much was clear. I could tell she was nervous, but she wasn't unprepared. There was an intelligence to her, one that made me want to know more. She wasn't just another intern trying to find her way—there was something deeper there.

When the meeting wrapped up, the group began to disperse, talking among themselves, continuing conversations in small huddles. I glanced toward Scarlett. She gathered her things quickly, her gaze darting nervously around the room, avoiding any unnecessary interaction. She was already backing away from the crowd, retreating to the safety of her own space.

I caught myself before I took another step in her direction. It wasn't like me to approach someone like that. To ask questions. To try to break down the walls

people put up. But there was something about her that made me want to peel away those layers and see what was underneath.

I needed to stop thinking like that.

But then Ethan nudged me. "I'm grabbing a drink later. You in?"

His voice pulled me back to the present, and I nodded absently. "Yeah, sure. I'll join you."

I had no idea what I was doing, but one thing was certain: I couldn't stop thinking about Scarlett Hayes. I didn't even know her last name, but the way she carried herself, the way she looked at the world--it haunted me.

Hours later, I found myself sitting at the bar with Ethan, nursing a drink. It was the kind of casual night we both needed--no work, no corporate masks. Just us, letting off some steam. But I couldn't shake the thought of her. Scarlett. The woman who had somehow gotten under my skin, even though I barely knew her.

Ethan was already deep in conversation with a woman who had approached him at the bar. She was attractive, with sharp features and a confident smile that suggested she was used to getting attention. I wasn't interested, not at the moment. My mind kept drifting back to Scarlett.

"You're quiet tonight," Ethan remarked, glancing over at me. His eyes followed mine, and a sly grin appeared on his face. "Still thinking about the intern?"

I shot him a glance. "No," I lied, though even I could tell it was a weak response.

Ethan chuckled, taking a sip of his drink. "You're a terrible liar, you know that? So, what's the deal with her? She seems a bit... out of place, don't you think?"

"Yeah," I murmured, more to myself than to him. "I guess she does."

We both turned our attention to the crowd, watching the people move around us.

The night was already thick with energy as I stood in the corner of the club, a drink in my hand, the buzz of conversation and music enveloping me. The

woman beside me, Chloe who is a fellow employee, had been keeping me entertained, but my mind was elsewhere. Her laughter was pleasant enough, the way she swayed with the beat of the music was enticing in its own right, but the moment Scarlett stepped onto the dance floor, I couldn't focus on anything else.

It had been a while since I had seen her--since the conference room. Scarlett Hayes. Her name echoed in my head as I stared at her, a woman who had unknowingly consumed my thoughts ever since that first meeting. I knew I should have been paying more attention to Chloe, trying to keep up the friendly banter, but Scarlett's presence pulled at my focus like a magnetic field.

She was no longer the nervous intern I had first seen in that sterile office environment. She had transformed into someone else entirely. The tight, formal clothing she had worn earlier in the day was gone. Now, she wore a dress that clung to her every curve, a deep shade of blue that shimmered under the club's neon lights. Her hair, usually neat and restrained, fell loosely around her shoulders, slightly disheveled from dancing. The way she moved--freely, confidently--was something I had never imagined from her. She had been a mystery before, quiet and reserved, but now, she seemed to be in her element.

And then there was the guy.

The man holding her by the waist, guiding her with a grip that spoke of ownership. They were close--too close for my liking. His hands roamed with an ease that made my stomach twist with jealousy. I didn't know why, but something about the way they danced--how she moved with him--felt off. Was she into him? Did she even notice me standing here, or was I just another face in the crowd?

I found myself staring at them, my gaze locked onto her, trying to make sense of it all. She looked... different. Gone was the uncertain woman I had seen earlier that day. In her place was someone who had shed the layers of anxiety, someone who seemed at ease, maybe even happy.

But why the hell was I feeling this way? She wasn't my type, and I didn't do relationships--certainly not with someone I had just met, not someone like her. Yet, as I watched her move in the guy's arms, a strange feeling twisted in my chest. Was this jealousy? Was this what it felt like to care about someone I barely knew?

Chloe was still talking, but I barely heard her. I was too caught up in watching Scarlett. I could see the way she laughed, the way her body moved fluidly with the rhythm of the music. For a moment, I lost track of time, only realizing when the music transitioned to something slower. Scarlett and her dance partner didn't seem to notice, though, lost in their own world.

But then, like a sudden wave crashing over me, the thought hit me--I needed to know her. Not just the quiet intern who avoided eye contact, but this woman, the one who could move like she was born for the dance floor. There was something more there, something that intrigued me. My curiosity had shifted into something more intense.

I turned to Chloe, who was now leaning in closer, her flirtatious smile unmistakable. She had her sights set on me, and I was fully aware of it. Yet, even as she brushed a finger against my arm, my attention was still firmly on Scarlett. I couldn't seem to tear myself away.

"Jude, you there?" Chloe asked, snapping her fingers in front of my face.

"Huh?" I blinked, pulling my gaze away from Scarlett for a moment, only to find Chloe right in front of me.

"You're distracted," Chloe said, her voice low, teasing. "You haven't even been paying attention."

I gave her a sheepish grin, trying to cover up the fact that my mind had been entirely preoccupied with someone else. "Sorry, got lost in thought for a second."

Chloe's lips curled into a knowing smile. "Lost in thought, huh? Or lost in her?" she said, glancing toward the dance floor where Scarlett was still dancing, this time with more freedom, more confidence.

I stiffened, feeling a heat rise in my chest. "What are you talking about?"

She didn't miss a beat. "I saw the way you were staring at her earlier. So, what's the deal with you and Miss Intern?"

I didn't have an answer to that question. "She's just someone I work with," I muttered, but even as I said it, I knew it sounded hollow.

"You sure about that?" Chloe raised an eyebrow, clearly amused by my discomfort. "Because I'd say there's more to it. You look like you're about to go rescue her from that guy."

I didn't respond, but my mind was racing. Could it be true? Was I drawn to her in some way I hadn't fully realized until now?

Before I could gather my thoughts, I saw the guy spin Scarlett around, pulling her close once more, their bodies pressed together, and that was when I knew. I was done pretending. This feeling--this feeling I couldn't shake--was something I hadn't experienced in a long time. I needed to know who she was, not just as an intern or a passing face in the office, but as a person.

Chloe was still by my side, her hand lightly resting on my arm as she flirted, but I felt like I was losing grip on the conversation. My focus was entirely on Scarlett, and it was impossible to ignore the pull I felt toward her.

I excused myself, trying to appear casual as I made my way through the crowd toward the bar. I ordered another drink, needing something to clear my head, but all I could think about was Scarlett. I had to be careful--she wasn't mine to claim, and I wasn't the type to go after women who weren't interested.

But I couldn't help it. My mind kept circling back to her. I tried to focus on the woman who had approached me at the bar, offering a flirtatious smile and a soft laugh. She had no idea what was going on in my head.

"Something wrong?" the woman asked, her voice low as she leaned in closer.

I forced a smile. "No, just tired."

She took a step back, narrowing her eyes. "Right. Well, I'm not here for a pity party." Her smile was playful, but I could tell she wasn't one for small talk.

I glanced over at the dance floor again, and that's when I saw it. Scarlett.

She had abandoned her dance partner for the moment, standing by herself, her gaze focused somewhere off in the distance, completely unaware that my eyes were locked on her. The dress she wore shimmered under the lights, and her messy hair framed her face in a way that made her look almost ethereal. But what caught me the most was the change in her--she wasn't the shy girl I'd seen before. This was a different side of her, one that made her look free, confident, even a little wild.

I couldn't stop staring. But what was even more intriguing was that, for the first time, Scarlett looked...alone. As if she had completely lost herself in the music, not needing anyone else. That made her all the more appealing, and I couldn't shake the feeling that I had to get closer. I wanted to understand her, to know her story. What was it about her that I couldn't ignore?

But as I stood there, lost in the moment, I didn't realize how long I had been staring until Chloe appeared at my side again, her hand on my shoulder. She didn't say anything, just followed my gaze and chuckled.

"See? Told you," she said.

I forced my gaze away, but even as I turned to face Chloe, all I could think was the same thing. Scarlett.

And I couldn't shake the thought--was she still the same quiet intern I had first met? Or was there something more to her? Something that was worth exploring?

But what did it mean? Why did I feel like this?

And more importantly, would I ever be able to stop thinking about her?

Chapter 5

Jude

The Monday after the club night, I walked into the office with a firm decision--I was done with this. Whatever this thing was with Scarlett Hayes--no, not a thing, just a passing curiosity--I was shutting it down. I was fucking Jude Emerson. I had a company to build, deals to close, and an empire waiting to be shaped. I wasn't about to get sidetracked by a girl who barely acknowledged my existence.

Yet, my first mistake was checking the intern files.

Not intentionally, of course. That would be ridiculous. I was merely scanning through the new hires for any names worth remembering. Future connections, potential recruits, that kind of thing. I wasn't looking for her--my hand just happened to pause when I saw the name.

Scarlett Hayes.

Somehow, knowing her name made it worse. It was like something intangible had suddenly become real. Now, she wasn't just that girl I saw at the office, the club, the conference hall. Now, she had an identity, a name that rolled off my tongue too easily. Scarlett. Fucking hell.

I closed the file, leaned back in my chair, and exhaled sharply. Nope. Not doing this.

For the entire morning, I kept my head down, throwing myself into work with laser focus. I was making a point--this was what mattered. Business. Numbers. Strategy.

Not some intern who had no clue I even existed.

"Jude, you listening?"

I looked up from my laptop. Ethan was standing over my desk, an eyebrow raised, his usual smirk in place.

"You've been staring at that screen like it holds the secrets of the universe," he remarked, plopping into the chair across from me. "What's up?"

"Nothing. Just focused," I replied, adjusting my posture.

Ethan snorted. "Bullshit. You look like someone just told you your stocks crashed."

"Maybe because I'm trying to make sure they don't crash," I shot back.

He studied me for a second, then grinned like he knew something I didn't.

"Ohhh, I get it now. This is about that little intern, isn't it?"

I stiffened. "What intern?"

"Oh, I don't know, the one you were eye-fucking across the conference hall?"

I glared at him. "I wasn't eye-fucking anyone."

"Right, right. And I'm a virgin priest who preaches loyalty." He leaned back, amused. "Look, man, I don't blame you. She's cute. Got that quiet, tortured-artist vibe going on. And I did see her at the club, so she's not as much of an ice queen as she looks."

My jaw ticked. I did not want to talk about that fucking club.

"Not interested," I said flatly.

Ethan smirked. "Yeah? Then why are you so tense?"

I picked up my phone, scrolling mindlessly. "Because I have better things to do than entertain whatever fantasy you're trying to push on me."

"Suit yourself." Ethan stood. "But if you ask me--"

"I didn't."

He laughed, holding up his hands in surrender. "Fine, fine. I'll let you get back to pretending you don't give a shit."

By the time night rolled around, I was done. Done with work, done with my own mind, done with this ridiculous fixation that I refused to name.

Which was why I ended up at Lustra, a dimly lit club with pulsing bass and the kind of women who knew the game and played it well.

I wasn't looking for anything specific--just a distraction.

And I found one.

She was blonde, bold, and confident. Dressed in a tight red dress that left very little to the imagination. She knew what she wanted, and she wasn't shy about making it clear.

"Jude Emerson, right?" she purred, her fingers tracing my arm. "I've seen you around."

I smirked, sipping my whiskey. "Have you now?"

"Oh, yeah," she leaned in, lips barely an inch from mine. "I've been waiting for the chance to catch your attention."

I let my eyes rake over her. She was gorgeous, and most importantly, she wasn't--

Don't fucking say her name.

I downed the rest of my drink and set the glass down with a dull thud. "Then what are we waiting for?"

Her smile widened, and within minutes, we were tangled together in one of the private booths. She straddled my lap, her hands in my hair, my hands on her waist, her lips tasting like cherry-flavored liquor and the promise of a long night.

She moaned against my mouth, grinding against me, fingers tugging at my shirt.

"You always this quiet?" she teased, nipping at my jaw.

I smirked, gripping her hips harder. "You won't be in a few minutes."

She laughed, a sultry sound that vibrated against my skin. "Confident, huh?"

"Always."

And for a while, I let myself get lost in it. In the heat, the touch, the way she moaned my name.

For a while, it worked.

Until I saw her.

At first, I thought I was imagining it. But no, there she was--Scarlett, on the dance floor, looking nothing like the nervous, guarded girl I had seen before.

Her hair was wild from dancing, her dress hugging every curve, her skin glistening under the flashing lights.

And there was a guy with her.

His hands were on her waist, pulling her close--too close. She wasn't even paying attention to him, lost in the music, her body moving in a way that was--

Fuck.

My jaw clenched, my grip on the blonde tightening.

"Something wrong?" she asked, breathless.

I forced a smirk. "Not at all."

She pulled me in for another kiss, but my mind was already elsewhere. Already tangled in something I didn't want to acknowledge.

Because the way Scarlett moved--like she didn't care, like she wasn't even thinking about the guy holding her--it made my chest tighten with something I didn't understand.

Was he her boyfriend?

And if he was, why did that thought make my fingers twitch?

I watched them for too long. Long enough that when I finally snapped out of it, the woman on my lap had noticed.

"You seem distracted," she murmured, tilting her head.

I exhaled slowly, forcing my attention back to her.

"Not at all," I lied smoothly, running my hands down her thighs. "Let's get out of here."

She grinned. "Finally."

And just like that, I made sure Scarlett Hayes was nowhere in my thoughts for the rest of the night.

At least, that's what I told myself.

Chapter 6

Scarlett

The light from the morning sun filtered through the blinds, bathing the apartment in a soft golden glow. My head was pounding, every beat of my pulse echoing in my skull. I groaned as I cracked open my eyes, only to wince at the brightness. The remnants of the previous night's fun were still with me--mostly the hangover that threatened to ruin my entire morning.

"Ughhh..." I muttered, throwing the blanket off me. It was still early, but the pounding in my head told me I wasn't getting much more sleep. I staggered to the kitchen, where Sofia and Maya were already lounging around, nursing their own coffees.

Maya, ever the optimist, grinned as I entered. "You look like death."

"Thanks," I replied dryly, squinting as I took a seat at the table, accepting the cup of coffee Sofia handed me. The warmth of it felt good against my hands, but it didn't do much for the headache.

Sofia shot me a sympathetic look. "You should've stopped at one drink last night, Scarlett."

"I did stop at one," I muttered, rubbing my temple. "Then Carla had to drag me into that tequila shot madness."

Carla walked into the kitchen with a mischievous grin, looking like she was already feeling like a million bucks. "What, you didn't have fun? I know you were dancing your ass off."

"I was," I admitted with a sigh, leaning back in my chair. "But I swear, that guy I was dancing with last night? He was way too clingy. It wasn't even worth it. I didn't even kiss him."

Maya raised an eyebrow. "Are you sure about that?"

I shot her a glare. "Yes, Maya. No kissing. I'm not interested in playing games with some random dude. I just danced and had fun."

"You should've kissed him," Carla teased, winking. "What's life without a little fun, huh?"

Sofia snorted. "For some people, Scarlett, that kind of thing is just... a Friday night thing."

I rolled my eyes. "Well, I'm not that person. And let's not even start on Carla."

Carla smirked, leaning against the counter. "What about me?"

"Did you hook up with that guy you were talking to?" I asked, fully knowing the answer. Carla wasn't the type to shy away from flirting, and last night she'd been all over some guy who had "mysterious eyes" or whatever it was that caught her attention.

"Yeah, I did," she shrugged nonchalantly, but there was a hint of satisfaction in her voice. "He's cute, and we might see each other again. Who knows?"

"Wait, so is he your boyfriend now?" Maya asked, eyes twinkling with mischief.

"Not yet," Carla replied with a wink. "But I'm not opposed to the idea."

Sofia laughed. "Of course you're not. You're never opposed to anything that looks good on paper."

I shook my head, grinning despite the hangover. "Honestly, you two have no shame."

Maya chuckled. "I've learned from the best."

"Don't act like you're not learning from Carla's playbook," I shot back.

It felt good to laugh and joke around, to not worry about anything for a while. College was almost over, and I couldn't help but feel a mix of excitement and fear. In a few months, everything would change. Maya was going to be working under a top celebrity fashion designer—her dream job. Sofia was well on her way to becoming a doctor, just like her parents always expected. And Carla... well, she was still figuring things out, but I knew she'd find her place.

As for me? I didn't know what the hell I was doing. It wasn't like I didn't have options--interning at Microsoft was a huge step in the right direction, but the uncertainty of it all still left me anxious. I was on my own now, no more school to hide behind.

"Well," Maya said as she stood up and stretched, "enough about us. How are you feeling about everything, Scarlett?"

"I don't know," I said honestly, running a hand through my tangled hair. "I guess I'm just trying to figure things out. I mean, work at Microsoft is great, but I keep questioning if I'm good enough for it."

"Girl, you're amazing," Carla said, giving me a pointed look. "They wouldn't have hired you if they didn't think you were the best."

"I know, but it still feels like I don't belong sometimes."

Sofia sat down across from me, her eyes softening. "You're doing fine. We all are. We might not know where we're headed, but that's part of the adventure. At least we've got each other."

I smiled at that, feeling a warmth spread through me. The three of them were always there for me, and no matter where life took us, I knew I could count on them.

"So," Maya began, clearly switching topics, "you didn't kiss the clingy guy last night, huh? Any other candidates?"

"Not really. I mean, the club was fun and all, but I'm not in the mood for anything serious right now." I shrugged. "I've got enough on my plate."

"Fair enough," Carla said, reaching for her phone. "But hey, it's not like you can't have fun, right? There's always next weekend."

I rolled my eyes. "You and your plans."

"I'm just saying," Carla teased, "there's always room for a little adventure."

"You two are hopeless," I laughed. "Maybe I'll just stick to reading my books for now."

"Oh, please, Scarlett. You need to get out more. Books won't distract you from your problems."

I raised an eyebrow. "They do, actually. They help me escape. Plus, I'm reading some romance novels that are better than anything real life has offered me."

Carla's eyebrows shot up. "Ohhh, we're talking about romance novels now? I thought you were anti-love."

"I am," I said quickly. "I don't believe in love, but it's fun to escape into a fantasy world for a little while."

The conversation naturally shifted back to their lives, and I listened as they bantered about their futures, their hopes, and their random thoughts about everything in between. It was nice to be surrounded by people who cared, people who didn't judge me for being lost or uncertain. In a way, they all had their paths figured out, but I didn't mind being the one who was still figuring it out.

After breakfast, we decided to head out and grab some fresh air. I needed a change of pace. I hadn't been to a bookstore in ages, and a good novel would help me clear my mind.

We ended up at the local indie bookstore, the cozy one with the soft, creaky floors and the scent of old paper. It was the perfect kind of place to get lost in.

As I browsed through the romance section, looking for something to dive into, I found myself getting lost in the covers and descriptions. Some books were silly, others dramatic, but they all offered an escape. A small smile tugged at my lips as I picked up a novel about a woman finding love in an unlikely place.

That's when I saw him.

Jude.

I froze for a second, my eyes locking onto his tall, broad figure at the far end of the aisle. He was browsing the same section, his back slightly turned as he ran a hand through his messy hair. He seemed focused, completely unaware of my presence. For a second, I didn't know what to think. What was he doing here?

I felt a strange flutter in my chest, but I quickly shook it off. No. Not today. I was here for books, not to get caught up in whatever strange pull this guy seemed to have on me. I tried to look away, pretending like I hadn't seen him, but I couldn't shake the feeling of being drawn to him, even if only for a moment.

I focused on the book in my hands, trying not to think about the man a few feet away. But I could feel him there. And I knew, for some reason, that my life was about to change. How, though, I had no idea.

Chapter 7

Scarlett

One fine Saturday morning, I found myself doing what I loved most--getting lost in a bookstore, searching for my next great love story. The air smelled like fresh paper, ink, and a faint hint of coffee from the small café inside. It was comforting, familiar. My fingers glided along the book spines as I scanned the shelves, trying to decide which fictional world to dive into next.

I was too absorbed in my search to immediately notice him.

Jude Emerson.

I recognized him the moment my eyes landed on him a few shelves away. It was the first time I had ever seen him outside of work in the past month since I had joined as an intern. He was always put-together, always confident--the kind of person people naturally gravitated toward.

But today, he was different.

Dressed in a white V-neck sweater with the sleeves pulled up and a pair of jeans, he looked far more casual than the sharp, professional image he carried at work. It suited him. The relaxed posture, the slightly tousled dark brown hair--it was a stark contrast to the composed, sharp-minded analyst who could effortlessly command a room.

But what caught me off guard the most was where he was standing.

The romance section.

I blinked. Jude Emerson, in the romance section of a bookstore?

I didn't know why, but it was oddly comforting to have something in common with him, even if it was something as simple as book preferences. Because in reality, we were nothing alike.

He was the center of attention at work--the one who could turn even the most critical situations into something manageable. He spoke with ease, carried himself with confidence. I, on the other hand, preferred to stay in the background, speaking only when necessary, my words always carefully measured. I was still processing this unexpected sight when I realized he was moving--toward me.

Panic twisted in my stomach. I was terrible at small talk, and the idea of having a conversation with him, of all people, made my mind race for ways to avoid it. But before I could even think of turning away, he was already standing beside me. For the first time, we acknowledged each other outside of work.

"Hi," he greeted, his voice casual and easy, like we had known each other for years.

I wasn't sure how he managed to make something as simple as a greeting sound so natural, but I envied it. I forced a polite smile. "Hey."

His eyes flickered to the book in my hand before moving back to the shelves. "Are you looking for something specific? I could help you find it."

I shook my head, tightening my grip on the book slightly. "No, I'm just deciding which one to pick. Nothing on my mind yet."

He nodded, his gaze scanning the rows of books in thought. "What genre do you like?"

I paused, glancing briefly at the shelf. Did he not realize where I was standing? But still, I answered, "I'm into romance novels."

The moment the words left my mouth, I saw it--the flicker of amusement in his eyes as realization dawned on him. He let out a small chuckle, rubbing the back of his neck.

"Right. That was a dumb question," he admitted with an easy grin.

I bit back a smile. "Maybe just a little."

His smile lingered for a moment before he glanced back at the shelves. "So... any recommendations?"

I blinked, caught off guard by the question. "You mean for romance books?"

"Yeah," he said, casually leaning against the shelf. "I've read a few, but I wouldn't mind something new."

I studied him for a moment, still finding it odd that he--of all people--read romance novels. But I pushed the thought aside and turned my attention to the books.

"Well... it depends. Do you like something lighthearted or more intense?"

He tilted his head slightly. "Something with depth. But not overly dramatic."

I nodded, scanning the shelves. After a moment, I pulled out a book and handed it to him. "This one's good. The characters are well-written, and it's not just about romance--it's about the emotional journey too."

He took the book from me, glancing at the cover. "Sounds like a good pick."

I grabbed a book for myself, and as we both settled on our choices, he glanced at me again. "Looks like we both found something worth reading."

"Yeah," I said, shifting the book under my arm.

There was a brief pause before he spoke again, his tone lighter. "Well, I guess I'll see you at work on Monday."

I nodded. "Yeah, see you."

And with that, we parted ways.

Somehow, it was easier to talk to him than I had expected. Maybe it was because he was welcoming, or maybe it was because--for once--I didn't have to overthink the conversation.

Maybe, just maybe, the world wasn't always as distant as I made it out to be. After he left the store I continued to find myself a book.

I should have been paying more attention to the book I was holding, but my mind kept returning to the conversation with Jude. It was strange, talking to him like that, outside of work, in a place that wasn't so formal. We had exchanged a few words, nothing extraordinary, but the simplicity of it was what made it feel different.

I hadn't expected the encounter to be so... easy. I didn't even know what I had expected, but it definitely wasn't that. Usually, when I spoke to people, I had to force the words out, making sure I wasn't saying anything dumb, second-guessing every little thing. But with Jude, there had been no pressure. No overthinking.

As I walked back toward the front of the bookstore, my thoughts kept circling back to him. There he was, standing in the romance section, of all places. I couldn't help but smile a little, still slightly amused by how unexpected that was. But I couldn't dwell on it. There was no point in overanalyzing it.

I had a goal here, and that goal was to find my next escape in the form of a romance novel. After all, that's why I came to the bookstore. And after all the distractions, I still hadn't found the perfect book.

I walked over to the mystery section and started browsing through it, hoping a change in genre might help me get my mind off the strange encounter I'd just had. But no matter how hard I tried, my thoughts kept drifting back to Jude--his casual smile, the way he asked for recommendations with such ease, how he didn't seem to make anything feel forced.

Maybe that's what got to me. He made everything seem so effortless. I pulled myself back from my wandering thoughts when I heard a familiar voice calling my name.

"Scarlett!"

I turned, seeing Maya walking toward me. She was grinning, looking as cheerful as ever, her dark hair flowing behind her like she had just stepped out of a shampoo commercial. As always, Maya had a way of making everything feel lighter. I couldn't help but smile.

"Hey!" I said, feeling some relief at the sight of my friend. "What are you doing here?"

Maya shrugged nonchalantly. "Same as you, I guess--finding my next escape." She glanced at my book with a raised brow. "Let me guess. Romance?"

"Yeah," I said, holding up the book. "Romance."

Maya rolled her eyes playfully, leaning in to take a closer look. "You know, there are other genres, right? You're allowed to broaden your horizons once in a while."

"I'm not saying I don't read other things," I replied, defending myself. "But sometimes, you need something predictable. Something that makes you feel all warm and fuzzy inside, you know?"

"I get it," she said, glancing around. "But you can only live on fluff for so long. It's like eating sugar all the time. Eventually, you'll crash."

I grinned at her. "So what did you find?"

"Just browsing." She pulled a few books from the shelf, flipping them over. "But I'm thinking something a little darker today."

I watched her, amused. Maya was always in a different mood when it came to books. While I preferred the predictable happily-ever-afters of romance, Maya liked to get lost in thrillers, mysteries, and stories that made her think.

"Hey, where's Carla?" I asked, glancing around the bookstore.

Maya waved a hand dismissively. "She's at home. She's been busy with... things."

"Things?" I repeated, raising an eyebrow.

"You know, things," Maya said cryptically. "Men, work, whatever. She's going through one of those phases. Trying to figure everything out."

I nodded, understanding the unspoken message. Carla had always been the one to take things slow, not rushing into anything but also never settling for less than what she deserved. It was one of the things I admired about her.

"Anyway, you still haven't told me why you're looking at romance novels," Maya said, nudging me with her elbow. "Are you planning on getting a little romantic on us, Scarlett?"

I shook my head, chuckling. "Hardly. I'm just looking for something to escape into. You know how it is."

Maya raised an eyebrow knowingly. "Uh-huh. Sure. Whatever helps you sleep at night."

I couldn't help but laugh. Maya had always had a way of seeing through me. Even if I didn't admit it, she knew me well enough to know when something was bothering me.

"Honestly, I don't know what I'm looking for," I admitted. "I guess... maybe I'm just overthinking it. I was just browsing, and then I saw... someone."

Maya's eyes lit up, an unmistakable grin forming on her face. "Ooh, someone? Who?"

I hesitated, biting my lip. "I don't know. It's stupid."

Maya's grin grew wider. "Come on, tell me. I won't judge."

I let out a deep breath. "It was Jude Emerson. I ran into him, and we talked. It wasn't anything huge. But... he was there. In the romance section. And for some reason, that just... stuck with me."

Maya nodded, her expression thoughtful. "Huh. That is interesting."

"Yeah," I said, running a hand through my hair. "I don't know why it's stuck in my head, though. We barely said anything, and yet it feels like it means something. But it doesn't. I mean, it's just a random encounter, right?"

"Sure," Maya said, sounding like she didn't quite believe me. "But maybe there's more to it. Maybe your subconscious is telling you something."

I rolled my eyes. "Don't start with the subconscious stuff. I'm just overthinking everything as usual."

Maya shrugged. "You know, that's one of your problems, right? You're always overthinking, always second-guessing yourself. But sometimes, things are just simple. And maybe, just maybe, this is one of those times."

I wasn't sure what to say to that, so I just nodded. "I guess you're right. It's just a guy in a bookstore."

"Exactly," Maya said, pulling me out of my thoughts. "Now, let's get you a book and get out of here before you start obsessing over Jude Emerson some more." I chuckled, grateful for Maya's ability to make light of everything. "I'm fine," I said, smiling. "Really."

She smiled back, and we wandered down the aisle together. I noticed she was holding a thriller novel, and I couldn't help but admire her taste in books. While I was content with romance and escapism, Maya always sought out stories that challenged her, that made her think.

"Hey," Maya said, turning to me with a mischievous grin, "I think I saw Carla walk past with a guy earlier. She was talking to him like they knew each other pretty well."

I raised an eyebrow. "Really?"

Maya nodded, smirking. "Yup. I think she's got a new thing going on. She didn't say anything, but I could tell by the way she was talking to him. He was cute, too."

I laughed, shaking my head. "Typical Carla. Never one to settle for less."

"Exactly," Maya agreed, holding up her book. "But you know what? I think it's good for her. She needs someone who challenges her a little. Someone who isn't afraid to keep up with her."

I nodded thoughtfully. "I guess so."

As we finished our browsing and made our way to the counter to check out, I couldn't help but think back to Jude. To that random encounter in the bookstore. It felt insignificant, but for some reason, it was staying with me. I had no idea why, but something about it was different. It wasn't just another fleeting conversation. There was a part of me that wanted to overanalyze it, but another part of me knew I shouldn't.

I paid for my book, and Maya and I headed out into the bright Saturday morning. But as I walked away, a question lingered in the back of my mind, something I couldn't quite shake off.

What was his reason for choosing romance as a genre?

It was such an odd, unexpected thing for someone like him. I couldn't help but wonder what drew him to it, what kind of emotions or experiences he was seeking in those pages. There was a mystery to that choice, one I wasn't sure I would ever understand...

Chapter 8

Jude

A bookstore wasn't exactly the place where I expected to run into Scarlett Hayes. But here she was.

I had come in search of a new book--something to escape into after an exhausting week. The store had its usual quiet hum--soft pages turning, muffled footsteps against polished wooden floors, the occasional beep from the register. It was a peaceful contrast to the fast-paced corporate world I spent most of my time in. But peace was the last thing I felt when my eyes landed on her.

Scarlett.

I recognized her immediately. She wasn't the first person I expected to see at a bookstore, but there she was, standing in the romance section like she belonged there.

It hit me in an unexpected way. I had seen her at work, in meetings, in the canteen, always the quiet observer, the one who rarely drew attention to herself. She was reserved, too careful, like she was always walking on eggshells. But today? Today was different.

Her red hair was tied in a lazy bun, strands escaping in soft waves around her face. She wore a simple white tank top and a cardigan, its fabric delicate, embroidered with tiny, colourful flowers. The contrast against her cherry-red hair made her look... effortlessly adorable. Her cargo pants were an odd mix of casual and comfortable, and yet, she pulled it off without effort. I couldn't help but smile.

What was it about this version of Scarlett that was so different? She wasn't tense, calculating, or second-guessing herself. She was... relaxed.

Carefree, even. Her movements were fluid, no longer the hesitant steps of someone who had to navigate a maze of uncertainty. And that smile--when it finally appeared--was like a breath of fresh air. For the first time, I saw Scarlett Hayes as she truly was, outside of the corporate world, without the layers of professionalism and self-doubt that masked who she really was.

It was as though I was seeing her for the first time. The woman behind the walls. The one who had become so elusive at work. But then it hit me.

She was standing right in front of the romance section. And I wasn't sure why, but it threw me off. I had never expected her to read romance novels. She always seemed so logical, analytical--someone who didn't believe in fairy tales or idealized love stories. Yet here she was, quietly sifting through the shelves, completely unaware of me standing there.

My mind raced. Was this something I could have predicted? Could I have known she had this side to her? She was an enigma, even to me. Every little detail about her was becoming a puzzle piece, and no matter how many times I tried to decipher her, I found myself falling short.

I forced myself to step back, to stop thinking too much. It was ridiculous, wasn't it? I couldn't keep overanalyzing everything about her. I had no reason to feel this way. She was just a coworker--a woman who had caught my attention, sure, but that was all it was. Right?

Still, my feet moved before I could stop them. I took two long strides and found myself beside her.

"Hi."

She turned around, and for the first time, I saw her eyes--those deep brown eyes that seemed so distant in the office--lock onto mine. I couldn't look away. There was something in her gaze that felt... unguarded, open. It was like the calm after a storm.

"Hey," she said, her lips curving into a small but genuine smile.

That smile. It caught me off guard, like a sucker punch to the gut. I had never seen her smile like that before. At work, she rarely let her guard down, always the quiet professional, the one who kept to herself. But here, in the quiet of the bookstore, her smile was warm, easy, like she was actually happy. The kind of smile that made my chest tighten with something I wasn't willing to admit. That smile wasn't just a reaction--it was a connection.

Her lips. I tried to focus on anything else, but it was impossible. They looked so kissable, and for a brief moment, I imagined myself leaning in, feeling the warmth of her skin, tasting the softness of her lips. Fuck, what was I doing? It wasn't the time or place to be thinking about that.

Get it together, Jude.

I quickly pushed the thought aside, refocusing on her voice when she spoke again. A soft, melodic tone with a hint of a Mexican accent. It was subtle, the kind of thing you might miss if you weren't paying attention. But I was paying attention--obsessively so.

And I hated myself for it.

Her voice was like a siren call, drawing me in. If I wasn't careful, I'd get lost in it, in her, in everything about her. It felt like the kind of pull that could swallow me whole.

"Are you looking for something specific?" she asked, breaking the silence between us.

I was tempted to ask her if she had any idea how much she was making me feel. But I didn't. Instead, I asked about the books.

She was easy to talk to, in a way I hadn't expected. The conversation flowed without effort. The calmness she exuded here, outside of work, was nothing like the woman I saw in the office. Scarlett was careful there, unsure. But here? She was herself. I found myself wondering why I hadn't approached her sooner. Why hadn't I ever spoken to her like this?

There was so much I wanted to say, to ask. But somehow, I found myself fumbling for the right words. It wasn't like me to be uncertain, to hesitate. But Scarlett... she was different. The more I tried to push past my hesitation, the more I wanted to dive deeper into this new side of her. The side that wasn't afraid to show her true self, her true emotions.

But I didn't. I held back.

As we continued to talk, I found myself getting lost in the rhythm of the conversation, in the way she seemed so genuine, so unaffected by the world around her. It was rare to find someone like that. I wanted more. But I didn't ask

for it. I didn't ask her to grab coffee, to sit down and talk longer. I didn't ask for any of it.

Instead, I just let it go.

"Well, I guess I'll see you at work on Monday," I said, my words trailing off, almost reluctantly.

It wasn't what I wanted. I didn't want to leave. I didn't want this to end.

But I did.

She nodded, offering a quick, "Yeah, see you."

And just like that, the conversation was over. I watched her walk away, my chest tight, my mind racing. I should've asked her to hang out, to grab that coffee. I should've taken the chance to explore whatever this was between us.

But I didn't.

And the weight of that decision pressed down on me.

As I stepped out of the bookstore, the cool air hit me, and I realized how badly I wanted to see her again. I couldn't stop thinking about her smile, her voice, the way she looked when she wasn't holding herself back.

But as I walked away, one thought lingered in my mind, an unanswered question that refused to leave me.

What was her reason for choosing romance as a genre?

Chapter 9

Jude

It wasn't a big deal when I invited Scarlett for coffee. A simple, casual suggestion, really. I didn't want to overthink it, but I'd be lying if I didn't admit a tiny part of me was hoping something would come out of it. It was all so natural, and yet, I couldn't shake the feeling that this wasn't just about books anymore.

I found myself strolling through the office in a way that felt a little too light. I didn't want to seem eager, but I couldn't help it. Today, I had that strange mixture of excitement and nervousness I hadn't felt in a while. Maybe it was just the curiosity I had about Scarlett, the way she always seemed to be a little more closed off than everyone else, and how, for some reason, I couldn't stop wanting to break that wall.

Our brief conversations during the past week had been easy--nothing heavy, nothing deep. I didn't push her for anything more, and neither did she. But there was a vibe I couldn't quite shake. She had an air about her that made me feel like I was missing something--something big. I wasn't entirely sure what it was, but it was there.

I spotted her in the canteen around noon, walking with that same grace, her soft cardigan brushing against her. It was like she had a certain calmness about her, even when the office buzzed around us. I couldn't help but smile when she looked up and saw me.

"Hey," I greeted her, my voice calm and steady despite the way my pulse quickened.

"Hey," she replied, her voice soft and light, her usual calm smile on her face.

"So," I began, stuffing my hands into the pockets of my jacket, trying to sound casual, "I've got a half-day today. Thought I could spend it in a more... meaningful way." I arched a brow, waiting for her to catch on.

She gave me a curious look, clearly wondering where I was going with this.

"Coffee," I said, smiling. "At the bookstore? You know, talk about books, maybe figure out what's so special about them."

She hesitated for a brief moment, and for some reason, I felt the sting of doubt. Would she say no? Was I reading this all wrong?

But then she smiled, and I knew I was right about one thing--there was something about her that made me want to get closer, to understand her more.

"Sure," she finally said, her tone calm but willing.

The bookstore café was quiet when we arrived, just the gentle hum of low conversations and the sound of pages turning. The scent of old books and fresh coffee filled the air. I led Scarlett to a table by the window, where the warm sunlight slanted across the room.

"After you," I said, gesturing to the chair across from me.

She smiled and sat down, placing her bag beside her. The way she carried herself, the way she moved--it was like she had an aura of calm about her. It was hard not to notice.

"Cold coffee? In this weather?" she teased as she looked at my drink choice.

I smirked. "Hot coffee? In this century?"

She raised an eyebrow but smiled. "You're full of surprises."

I grinned, leaning back in my chair. "You're just judging me, aren't you?"

"Not at all," she replied, her eyes twinkling with amusement. "Maybe just a little."

I chuckled, feeling oddly comfortable around her. "We even contradict each other's coffee choices. Hot and cold. Balance the universe, right?"

"Balance the universe? Sure," she replied, rolling her eyes but clearly entertained. "I never thought coffee was so profound."

"Well," I said with a playful shrug, "everything's profound if you think about it long enough."

She gave a small laugh, the kind that made her whole face light up. And for a moment, it was just us, laughing together like we'd known each other for ages.

We spent the next few minutes talking about books--what we liked, what we didn't. I told her she needed to expand her genre beyond romance, and she told me I had no idea what I was missing. It was effortless, and for once, I didn't feel the need to impress or perform. I just... was.

Then, out of nowhere, she asked, "Why do you choose romance as your genre?"

I wasn't expecting the question, but it was a good one. A thoughtful one. I leaned forward, resting my elbows on the table as I thought about my answer.

"Why not?" I replied with a grin. "It's got everything--emotions, conflict, passion. All the good stuff. But mostly, it's about hope. You know?" I looked into her eyes. "I love the idea that, no matter how flawed people are, they can still find someone who loves them for who they are. Flaws and all."

She stayed quiet for a moment, her expression unreadable. I could feel the change in the air, the slight shift in her demeanour.

"And you?" I asked, raising an eyebrow. "Why do you read romance?"

She hesitated, her fingers tracing the edge of her cup.

"I love reading about it. But as for hoping to find it?" She shook her head. "No, I don't think it exists in real life."

I felt a pang in my chest.

"You don't think love exists?" I asked, keeping my tone light, trying not to push too hard.

She shrugged. "Not the way books describe it. People lie. They cheat. They break your heart. It's just... too much to expect. So I stopped."

Her words weren't bitter. But they were resigned.

And I hated it.

I hated that someone had made her believe love wasn't real.
Whoever it was, I wanted to find them. I wanted to know exactly what they did to her. Because for the first time in my life, I was pissed at someone I had never even met.

"You don't think there's someone out there who would love you for who you are?"
I asked, my voice quieter now.

She looked up, her gaze meeting mine. "Maybe. But I don't think it's that simple."
I swallowed, feeling something shift inside me.

Because in that moment, I knew.

I wanted to change her perspective.

I wanted to show her that real, one true love did exist.

And there was no going back from this.

Now that I had started to know her...

Now that I had seen her smile, heard her laugh...

I wanted more.

I wanted to be the reason for those smiles. I wanted to hear that laugh again. I wanted her sarcasm, her wit, her everything.

I wanted to know what happened to her that made her lose hope in love.

And more than anything, I wanted to prove to her that she was wrong.

That love wasn't just real--it was standing right in front of her.

She glanced at her watch. "I should go."

I stood up as she did. "We should do this again sometime."

She nodded, that small, unreadable smile on her lips. "Maybe."

I watched her walk away, and everything around me faded into the background.

Because I knew now.

I had fallen for her.

And there was no way in hell I was letting this go.

Chapter 10

Scarlett

The problem with people like Jude Emerson was that they didn't know what it was like to have their hopes shattered.

They walked around with their beliefs intact, carrying the idea of love like it was some kind of magical force that found its way to everyone. He spoke about it as if it were an undeniable truth--one true love, someone who would love you despite your imperfections, a connection so strong it defied everything else.

It was easy for him to believe that. No one had ever made him question it.

But he would learn.

He would realize, just like I did, that love is not some predestined, unwavering force. It's a gamble, and most of the time, you lose.

I wasn't going to let myself forget that.

For the past two weeks, I had successfully avoided getting too comfortable with him. My exams were close, and they gave me a good enough reason to distance myself. I worked from home most days, drowning myself in studying and making sure I didn't have time to think about unnecessary things--like the way his voice sounded when he made a joke, or how easily he could get a laugh out of me.

I barely saw him. Only once or twice in passing when I had to go into the office. The first time, it was just a polite nod. The second, a brief "Hey." Nothing more. Nothing that could make me slip back into whatever that easy, comfortable rhythm we had started falling into.

This was better.

I kept my days structured. Mornings started with coffee and books, afternoons were filled with notes and practice questions, and evenings were spent revising or listening to music to drown out my thoughts. Carla had offered to help me study, but I declined. She had already noticed that I was pulling away a little.

"Are you okay?" she had asked one evening when we were both in the apartment, her eyes studying me like she could see through every excuse I wanted to give.

"Yeah, just stressed about exams," I had said, giving her my best attempt at a reassuring smile.

She didn't seem convinced, but she let it go.

I didn't tell her or any of my friends about Jude.

If they knew we had been talking more, they would push. They would tease, speculate, and, worst of all, they would hope. And I couldn't afford hope.

The problem with keeping my distance was that my mind didn't get the memo.

No matter how much I buried myself in studying, Jude Emerson still found a way to creep into my thoughts at the most random times.

Like when I brewed my coffee and, for a split second, imagined him sitting across from me with his ridiculous cold coffee, smirking as he made some sarcastic remark about how I was stuck in the past.

Or when I read a romance novel and found myself wondering what he would think of it.

Or when I sat on my bed at night, exhausted, and my brain decided it was the perfect time to replay our last conversation.

He had said he believed in love because, no matter how imperfect someone was, there was always someone out there who would love them anyway.

It was a nice thought.

A naive one.

And yet, it stayed with me.

I hated that.

Two weeks had passed like this. My exams were almost over--just two more left. I had been working remotely most of the time, but today, I had to go to the office for a mandatory meeting.

I went in, attended the meeting, and made my way to the canteen afterward for a quick coffee before heading back home. That was when I saw him.

Jude was sitting at a table near the window, casually scrolling through his phone, a cup of iced coffee in front of him.

Of course.

He looked up right as I reached the counter. Our eyes met for a second, and something unreadable flickered across his face before he smirked.

"Still drinking that ancient hot coffee, I see."

I sighed, shaking my head as I placed my order. "And you're still stuck in your questionable life choices."

He chuckled. "You haven't been around much."

"Exams," I said simply.

He nodded, then gestured toward the seat across from him. "Sit with me for a bit?"

I hesitated. Just for a second.

I could say no. I should say no.

But instead, I found myself sitting down.

I told myself it was just a few minutes.

The conversation was effortless, like it always was with him. We talked about books, debated over genres, and--unsurprisingly--argued over coffee again.

"Cold coffee is objectively better," he said, taking a slow sip.

"In what world?" I scoffed. "You're basically drinking ice-cold milk with a hint of caffeine."

"Ah, but that 'hint' is what makes it elite," he countered. "Meanwhile, you're over here burning your tongue on overpriced lava."

I rolled my eyes but couldn't stop the small smile tugging at my lips. "We even contradict each other's choice of coffee."

"Maybe we balance each other out," he mused, his hazel-green eyes glinting with amusement.

I huffed. "That's a bit of a stretch."

He just smirked and sipped his drink.

For a while, I forgot why I had been avoiding him.

At some point, the topic shifted back to books. I asked him if he had read anything new, and he mentioned another romance novel.

I gave him a look. "Still sticking with romance, huh?"

"Yup," he said easily. "And before you judge me, you should know it was actually pretty good."

I shook my head with a small laugh. "I don't get it. Why romance?"

He tilted his head slightly, as if considering his answer. "Why not?"

I shrugged. "I don't know. It just seems... I don't know, overly idealistic?"

He leaned forward slightly, resting his arms on the table. "And you don't like idealism?"

"I don't believe in it."

A pause.

He watched me for a second, his gaze searching. "You used to, though."

It wasn't a question. It was a statement.

And the worst part? It was true.

I swallowed. "Maybe. But not anymore."

Something about the way he looked at me made me feel like he wanted to ask why. Like he wanted to pry, to unravel the layers I had worked so hard to keep intact.

But he didn't push.

He just sat back and said, "You know, one day, I might just change your mind."

I scoffed. "Good luck with that."

He grinned. "I like a challenge."

I left shortly after that.

But as I walked away, I couldn't shake the feeling that he wasn't done. That this wasn't just some fleeting conversation to him.

Jude wasn't the type to force things, but he also wasn't the type to let things go easily. And now that I had seen the way he looked at me--the quiet determination in his eyes--I knew.

He wanted to prove me wrong.

He wanted to show me that love wasn't a lie.

And that terrified me.

Because if anyone could make me believe in it again... it was him.

Chapter 11

Jude

The morning air was crisp as I walked into the office, my mind occupied with the pile of work waiting for me. Meetings, strategies, numbers--it was all part of the game. A game I had mastered over the years. But today, there was something else lingering in the back of my mind, something--or rather, someone--I wasn't used to factoring into my day.

Scarlett Hayes.

I never thought one coffee date--or whatever the hell it was--could change so much. But here I was, stepping into the office, hoping to catch a glimpse of her cherry-red hair in the crowd, hoping to hear that quiet, sarcastic tone of hers, hoping for just a fraction of the ease we had at the bookstore café. And yet, she wasn't here.

Not yesterday. Not the day before.

I had started thinking I messed up--that maybe I had said something that pushed her away. Maybe she had changed her mind about even being remotely friendly with me. It wasn't like I had asked her out on a proper date, but I had challenged her. One day, I'll prove you wrong. And maybe that was the mistake. I wasn't sure what the hell I wanted from her. But what I did know was that I wasn't ready to stop seeing her.

"Hey, man," Ethan's voice broke through my thoughts as he approached my desk, a cup of coffee in hand. "You look like you're solving quantum physics. What's up?"

I shook off my thoughts, leaning back in my chair. "Just thinking."

He pulled up a chair, stretching his long legs. "About?"

I hesitated. Ethan didn't know about Scarlett--not in the way that mattered. Sure, he knew she worked here, but he didn't know I had spent an entire hour and a half debating book genres with her, making her laugh, watching her smile, and wondering why the hell that smile stayed in my head long after she was gone. Instead, I chose the safer topic. "The business."

Ethan smirked, his expression shifting from curiosity to excitement. "Ah, finally. So, are we talking big moves now?"

I nodded, rolling my shoulders. "Microsoft has been good, but it's not the endgame. We always knew that."

"We did," Ethan agreed. "But let's be real, Jude. The comfort of a paycheck--especially a fat one--isn't easy to walk away from."

"It never was about the paycheck," I countered. "It was about learning, about understanding how things work on a large scale. We've been here long enough. We have connections, we have resources, and we sure as hell have the ideas." Ethan leaned forward, intrigued. "So, what are we looking at?"

Tech startup? Consulting firm?"

"Both," I said simply. "The market is shifting. AI is booming, businesses need data-driven solutions, and most big corporations are stuck in outdated models. We build something that merges both worlds--a hybrid of AI-powered business consulting. Real-time analytics, automation, and market strategies designed by machine learning."

Ethan let out a low whistle. "That's... ambitious. But it could work. We'd need investors."

"I already have a few in mind," I said, tapping my fingers on the desk. "It's all about timing. We pitch it too soon, we lose leverage. Too late, and we're just another name in a sea of startups."

Ethan studied me for a moment before grinning. "You've really been thinking about this."

"Always," I admitted. "We didn't come this far to work for someone else forever."

"Damn right," Ethan smirked. "Let's set up a meeting. See where we stand."

I nodded, my mind already shifting into business mode. It was easy. It was familiar. But as I glanced around the office one more time, searching for a glimpse of red hair that wasn't there, I realized something.

For the first time in a long time, business wasn't the only thing on my mind.

A week passed. Then another.

Scarlett was still scarce.

At first, I thought she was avoiding me. But then I overheard a conversation--one of her teammates mentioning her exams. That was when the tension in my chest eased a little. She wasn't running away from me. She was just busy.

I should've left it at that. But somehow, her absence was louder than her presence.

Every time I grabbed coffee in the canteen, I found myself wondering if she'd suddenly walk in. Every meeting, I subconsciously checked if she was there. It

was ridiculous, really. I wasn't the type to get hung up on someone. But Scarlett? She had a way of getting under my skin without even trying.

Maybe it was the way she spoke--reserved, but sharp. Maybe it was the way she laughed--rare, but unguarded when it happened. Maybe it was the way she looked at me--like she was constantly trying to figure me out but refused to let me figure her out.

And maybe--just maybe--it was the way she didn't believe in love.

It wasn't just skepticism. It wasn't some cynical phase. She truly, wholeheartedly believed it didn't exist.

And that? That pissed me off more than it should have.

I didn't know who broke her, but for the first time in my life, I was angry at someone I had never met.

It was a Friday evening when I finally saw her again.

I had just wrapped up a long meeting when I spotted her in the hallway, typing something on her phone. She was wearing a simple black sweater, her hair falling over her face as she concentrated.

Something in my chest shifted.

I had missed her.

It wasn't some fleeting thought. It was real. Raw. And fucking terrifying.

I cleared my throat as I approached. "Didn't know you still worked here."

She looked up, startled, then rolled her eyes when she saw me. "Funny."

"Where have you been?" I asked, keeping my tone casual. "Thought you finally quit."

She sighed, tucking her phone away. "Exams. College exists, remember?"

"Right," I nodded. "The part where you prove you're a genius."

She smirked slightly. "I never said I was a genius."

"No, but I'm assuming," I shot back. "And I'm rarely wrong."

She huffed a laugh, shaking her head. And damn, I had missed that sound.

We stood there for a moment, silence settling between us. She was about to say something, but I beat her to it.

"You know," I said, watching her carefully, "I meant what I said."

She frowned. "About what?"

"About proving you wrong." I tilted my head slightly. "One true love exists, Scarlett."

Something flickered in her eyes, but she masked it quickly. "You're still on that?"

"Always." I grinned. "You know me--stubborn as hell."

She shook her head, a mix of amusement and exasperation on her face. "You really think you can change my mind?"

I took a step closer, lowering my voice just slightly. "I think you're scared that I might."

Her breath hitched--just for a second. And that? That was enough.

I smirked, stepping back. "See you around, Scarlett."

As I walked away, one thought ran through my mind.

There was no going back from this.

I had started something. And I wasn't going to stop until I saw it through.

Because Scarlett Hayes didn't believe in love.

And I?

I was going to make her believe.

Chapter 12

Scarlett

The final exam paper lay face down on the desk in front of me, my name scrawled in black ink at the top. My heart still pounded from the last-minute rush to complete the final question before time was up.

It was over.

For weeks, I had lived in a cycle of caffeine, sleepless nights, and self-doubt, and now? Nothing but silence. The kind of silence that came after the storm, leaving behind an unsettling emptiness.

I stepped outside the university gates, the crisp evening air brushing against my skin. Before I could process my relief, my phone buzzed aggressively in my pocket.

Sofia: Nightclub. Tonight. No excuses.

Carla: I already picked your outfit. If you argue, I'll show up at your apartment.

Maya: You owe us a wild night after torturing yourself over exams. Let's go.

I sighed, a small smile tugging at my lips. They weren't going to let me say no. And maybe I didn't want to.

Empire was a beast of a club--packed, pulsing, and alive with neon lights that flickered in sync with the heavy bass. The smell of expensive perfume, sweat, and alcohol lingered in the air, blending into something intoxicating.

The four of us pushed our way inside, giggling as Sofia immediately yanked out her phone.

"First--photos," she declared. "We need proof that we survived finals."

Carla groaned. "Do we really?"

"Yes. We're hot, we're free, and we need to document it."

Maya and I exchanged amused glances before giving in. We huddled together, striking poses under the dim, flashing lights. Sofia took a quick video, spinning

the camera to show off our outfits--Carla in her sleek, tight dress, Maya in something effortlessly sexy, Sofia exuding confidence as always, and me... Scarlett Hayes in a dress that Carla forced me into.

It was shorter than what I was used to, clinging to my curves, the deep red fabric hugging my waist. My legs felt exposed. My arms felt bare. But despite my initial discomfort, I had to admit--I didn't look half bad.

We ordered drinks, downing them with ease before heading straight to the dance floor.

The music hit deep in my bones, reverberating through my chest as we moved together in rhythm. I let the bass guide me, my body swaying, my hips rolling. Sofia had already found a guy, her hands tangled in his hair. Carla wasn't far behind, whispering something in the ear of a tall, broad-shouldered man who seemed utterly captivated by her. Maya laughed as she twirled away from her dance partner, teasing him before pulling him back in. And then there was me.

I was trying.

When a guy with messy blond hair approached me, I let him talk. Let him flirt. His hand grazed my waist, lingering in an invitation.

But I couldn't do it.

Something inside me resisted, something cold and unyielding.

I moved away, just enough to keep dancing but not enough to encourage him. He wasn't the problem--I was.

I didn't know how to let go.

The thought weighed on me as I let myself sink into the music, moving alone, content with my own space. But then--

A hand.

Too firm, too bold, pressing against my lower back.

I stiffened immediately.

"Hey," a voice murmured close to my ear. "You look lonely, sweetheart."

I turned sharply. The guy was taller than me, dark eyes gleaming under the flashing lights. His fingers slid lower, his touch growing bolder.

I forced a small, polite smile. "I'm just here to dance."

"Then dance with me," he said smoothly, his grip tightening.

I shifted, trying to step back, but his grip didn't loosen. My stomach twisted.

“|--”

His other hand brushed against my arm. Too much. Too close.

“I don’t think she’s interested.”

The voice was smooth, but laced with something sharp.

I didn’t have to turn around to know who it belonged to.

Jude.

The guy holding me hesitated, eyes flicking over my shoulder. “Relax, man.

We’re just talking.”

Jude’s presence behind me was a wall--solid, unmoving, dangerous.

“Then let’s make this simple,” Jude said. “You walk away now, and I don’t have to make you leave in ten different ugly ways.”

The guy scoffed, but his hands slid off me. “Jesus. Overprotective much?”

Jude stepped forward, his voice dropping lower. “Try touching her again, and we’ll find out exactly how protective I can get.”

Something about the way he said it sent a shiver down my spine.

The guy gave me one last glance before muttering something under his breath and disappearing into the crowd.

Jude exhaled, his fingers brushing my waist as he turned me slightly toward him. “You okay, *Rose*?”

His touch was gentle now.

Reassuring.

But my heart was still racing--for an entirely different reason.

I nodded. “Yeah. He was just--persistent.”

Jude’s jaw ticked. “Persistent is a polite word for it.”

I huffed a small laugh, trying to shake the lingering nerves. But now, there was a new kind of tension between us.

A different kind of charge in the air.

Jude didn’t move his hand from my waist.

And I didn’t step away.

The club pulsed around us, people moving, bodies pressing together, but it felt like a distant world. Right now, it was just him.

And me.

I tilted my head up slightly, my eyes tracing his features--sharp jawline, perfectly tousled dark brown hair, those intense hazel-green eyes. He smelled like cedarwood and something else, something warm and intoxicating.

His fingers flexed against my waist.

I swallowed.

He was watching me just as closely, his gaze flickering from my eyes to my lips. God.

I wanted to know.

Wanted to feel the way his lips would press against mine. If they'd be slow and deliberate or rough with impatience. If he'd taste like whiskey or something darker, something uniquely him.

Jude's head dipped lower.

My breath caught.

His nose brushed against mine, his fingers tightening ever so slightly. My pulse hammered against my skin.

I swayed forward, just an inch, just enough to--

He smirked.

And then he fucking laughed.

I blinked, thrown completely off balance as he pulled back, amusement flickering across his features.

"Damn, Rose," he murmured, shaking his head. "I knew you had a thing for me, but I didn't think you'd be this obvious about it."

Heat flared up my spine. "Excuse me?"

He grinned, leaning just close enough to drop his voice. "You were staring at my lips like you were about to commit a sin."

"I was not--"

"You totally were," he teased, eyes twinkling with mischief. "If you wanted to kiss me, you could've just said so."

"Oh my god," I groaned, shoving at his chest.

He caught my wrist, his grip firm but playful. "You weren't?" His gaze flickered down to my lips once more. "Because from where I was standing, it definitely looked like you wanted to."

I scowled, my heart still a fucking mess. "You're insufferable."

Jude chuckled, finally releasing my wrist. "And you're bad at hiding your feelings."

I should've argued.

Should've told him he was wrong.

But the truth?

I had wanted to kiss him.

And I had no idea why I couldn't.

As I watched Jude walk away, still smirking, I exhaled shakily, pressing my fingers to my lips.

What the hell was happening to me?

Chapter 13

Jude

The office was dimly lit, the only source of light coming from the floor-to-ceiling windows that overlooked the city skyline. The glow of New York stretched endlessly before me, a sea of flickering lights, a constant reminder of why I was here--why I was doing this.

I leaned back in my chair, exhaling slowly as I stared at the numbers on the screen.

Progress.

Ethan and I had been working on this business plan for months--endless meetings, late-night calls, strategy sessions that bled into early mornings. And now, it was finally happening. Our own company. Our own empire.

A slow smirk tugged at my lips.

I wasn't the type to follow rules--I never had been. I had learned early on that power belonged to the ones who took it. That's why I refused to spend my life making money for someone else, playing by someone else's game.

I made the rules.

And now, we were close to launching something that would change everything.

A knock at the door pulled me from my thoughts.

Ethan strolled in, a coffee in one hand, a stack of papers in the other. He looked as confident as ever, like he already knew we were going to win before the game even started.

"You're still here," he observed, setting the coffee on my desk. "Not that I'm surprised."

I picked up the cup, taking a sip. "You sound shocked."

"Not shocked. Just wondering how long it'll take before you admit you don't sleep anymore."

I smirked. "Sleep is for people who aren't building an empire."

Ethan chuckled, shaking his head as he sat down across from me. "Speaking of empires, we need a name."

I exhaled, rolling my shoulders back. We had been tossing ideas back and forth for weeks, trying to come up with something that felt right. Something that represented us--not just another corporate name, but a symbol of everything we were about to create.

My fingers drummed against the desk as I stared at the city below.
Then it hit me.

Echelon.

The word came out before I could second-guess it.

Ethan raised an eyebrow. "Echelon?"

I nodded slowly, the name settling into my bones like it had been there all along. "It means the upper ranks. The highest level. That's what we're building, right?"

Ethan leaned back in his chair, considering. Then, a slow grin spread across his face. "Echelon." He let the word roll off his tongue like he was testing its weight. "I like it."

Something clicked into place.

This was it.

This was ours.

Echelon.

The beginning of everything.

The moment I stepped inside Empire, I was reminded why I hated clubs.

Loud music. Crowds of people who thought alcohol made them invincible. Flashing lights that gave the illusion of a good time when, really, everyone here was just trying to forget something.

But I wasn't here for fun.

I was here to meet an investor.

I adjusted the cuffs of my shirt, my mind still buzzing with business strategies as I made my way to the VIP section. Ethan had set up this meeting, and if all went well, we'd secure another major player backing Echelon.

I was supposed to be focused.

But then--

I saw her.

Scarlett.

And just like that, every rational thought in my head disintegrated.

She was on the dance floor, moving in a way that didn't belong in a club like this. There was no desperation in her movements, no attempt to impress. She wasn't seeking attention, wasn't throwing herself into someone's arms for the sake of the night.

She was just... there.

Existing.

Glowing under the neon lights, lost in the music, unaware of how dangerous she looked.

And then I noticed something else.

She wasn't wearing her glasses.

I had never seen her without them before.

Without them, there was nothing guarding those deep brown eyes. Nothing shielding the emotions that flickered through them. And fuck, I had spent so long trying to understand her--trying to see her through the walls she put up--but right now?

She was bare.

Raw.

And fucking breathtaking.

Her cherry-red hair cascaded down her back in soft waves, wild and untamed. The dress she wore was short, hugging every delicate curve of her body. It was a shade of deep red, almost the same color as her lips--plump, unmarked, untouched by anything that would make them undeserving of being kissed.

I swallowed hard.

Something in my chest twisted.

Scarlett Hayes was not made for a place like this.

She didn't belong in the arms of strangers, didn't belong in the haze of alcohol and empty touches.

She belonged--

Fuck.

I didn't get to finish that thought, because that's when I saw him.

A man.

Standing too close.

Touching her like he had any right.

I went still.

Then something dark and murderous crawled up my spine.

The world around me blurred.

Everything else--the music, the flashing lights, the entire fucking club--became irrelevant.

All I saw was him.

His hand sliding lower. His body leaning into hers.

Scarlett trying to step back.

And him not letting her.
Blood roared in my ears.
It wasn't just anger.
It was something primal.
A kind of rage that didn't feel like my own. A kind that didn't come from logic
or reason. A kind that said kill.
I wanted to break his fucking hands.
Wanted to watch as he realized he had just made the worst mistake of his life.
I could already see it--could already feel how easy it would be to grab him by the
collar, slam his head into the nearest table, watch as the blood dripped onto
the floor--
Stop.
I inhaled sharply, my fists clenched so tightly my nails dug into my palms.
I didn't have time to do something fucking stupid.
So I moved.
I crossed the distance between us, my voice sharp and unwavering as I told the
bastard exactly what was going to happen to him if he didn't walk
away immediately.
He left.
Coward.
And then it was just her.
Scarlett.
Her breathing was uneven, her lips parted slightly.
I didn't even think about it when my hand found her waist. I needed to touch her,
needed to ground myself, needed proof that she was okay.
And fuck--
She was warm.
Soft.
Her skin burned through the fabric of her dress, her scent wrapping around me
like a drug--something sweet, something fucking dangerous.
Then she looked up at me.
And my world tilted.
I should have left.
Should have walked away before I did something reckless.
But I didn't.
Because for the first time, she wasn't guarded.
For the first time, she was letting me see her.

I wanted to kiss her.

Desperately.

Painfully.

But I didn't.

Because Scarlett Hayes wasn't meant to be touched in a fleeting moment of impulse.

She wasn't meant to be kissed under the haze of neon lights, in the middle of a club where people forgot themselves.

Scarlett wasn't temporary.

And if I kissed her now, I knew--

I wouldn't stop.

Ever.

I exhaled sharply, forcing myself to step back, forcing my body to walk away before I ruined this.

Before I ruined her.

But as I made my way toward the VIP lounge, my mind was still full of her.

Scarlett.

Scarlett.

Scarlett.

And fuck--

I wasn't sure I'd ever be able to forget the way she looked tonight.

Chapter 14

Scarlett